

Norris tames Mad Max to reaffirm title credentials

McLaren's Lando Norris **dominated** the Singapore Grand Prix, cutting further into Max Verstappen's championship lead.

S. Dipak Ragav

dipak.ragav@thehindu.co.in

Now that 75 per cent of the 2024 Formula One season is done following the double-header in Azerbaijan (September 15) and Singapore (September 22), the stage is set for an exciting finish. The championship battles for both the drivers and constructors are well and truly alive, with just six races remaining.

McLaren driver Lando Norris delivered a near-perfect weekend in Singapore, dominating from pole position and leading every lap of the race to clinch his third career victory. The win puts him 52 points behind championship leader Max Verstappen, with six races remaining, including three Sprint events in the USA, Brazil, and Qatar. Although it's still a tall order, Norris will fancy his chances of dethroning Verstappen, especially with 180 points still on the table.

Red Bull and Verstappen have not won a race since the Spanish Grand Prix in June, illustrating the reigning champion's precarious position, despite holding a two-race win's worth of a lead. Red Bull has struggled in recent events, even to fight for the podium. Fortunately for Verstappen, in Singapore, the car was good enough to qualify second on the grid. While Norris cruised to victory, Verstappen came in a distant second, nearly 21 seconds behind his rival but comfortably ahead of Oscar Piastri in the second McLaren.

Piastri masterclass in Baku

It was a much-needed win for Norris following the disappointment in Baku, where

an untimely yellow flag during qualifying ruined his weekend. After being knocked out in the first part of qualifying, Norris started 15th but fought back to finish fourth, one place ahead of Verstappen.

However, it was a bittersweet weekend for McLaren. Piastri showed what was possible by taking his second career win, producing one of the best drives of the season.

The Australian put on a defensive masterclass, keeping Ferrari's Charles Leclerc at bay, soaking up the pressure, and not putting a foot wrong.

Leclerc controlled the first part of the race, starting from pole and building a six-second advantage before the first round of pit stops. Things got interesting when the drivers switched to hard compound tyres. Piastri, who stopped a few laps earlier, was able to quickly reduce Leclerc's lead, as the Ferrari driver struggled to get his new tyres up to temperature. On lap 20, Piastri made a brave move on the brakes, diving inside Leclerc at turn one when the Ferrari driver least expected it, taking the lead.

For the next 31 laps, Leclerc threw

Dominant win: Lando Norris led every lap of the Singapore Grand Prix and ensured Max Verstappen finished a distant second in his Red Bull. REUTERS

